
Arthur Honegger

1892–1955, SWISS

A member of the group of Parisian composers known as Les Six, Honegger was born in France to Swiss parents. He studied at the conservatory in Zurich before moving to the Paris Conservatoire in 1911 and settling in Montmartre, where he spent most of his life. He established an early reputation with works such as the 1918 ballet *Le Dit des jeux du monde*, before his oratorio *Le Roi David* brought international renown. Associated with Les Six by friendship rather than compositional style, he produced a string of thoroughly individual works, some reflecting his extra-musical interests in sports and locomotives. As well as heavyweight orchestral and choral pieces, he wrote popular operettas and film music, including the score for Abel Gance's epic *Napoléon* (1926). In 1931, he married the pianist Andrée Vaurabourg, although the couple lived separately because of Honegger's need for solitude. His later life was darkened by illness and somber reflections on the state of the world.

KEY WORKS: *Le Roi David* (oratorio), 1921; *Pacific 231* (Symphonic Movement No 1), 1923; *Jeanne d'Arc au bûcher* (oratorio), 1935; *Symphony No. 3*